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LAW

DEFINITION OF LAW

Law is a system of rules established and enforced by a recognized authority for the purpose of regulating human conduct.

JOHN AUSTIN'S DEFINITION OF LAW

John Austin, a renowned legal philosopher, defined law as "the command of a sovereign backed by the threat of sanction."

Law deals strictly with facts. For any law to be applied or enforced, evidence is of utmost importance.

CHARACTERISTICS OF LAW

1. **Binding:** Law is compulsory and must be obeyed by all citizens.

2. **Enforceable:** The state has the power to compel obedience through law enforcement agents and the courts.

3. **Universal Application:** Law is meant for everyone; nobody is above the law (Rule of Law).

4. **Regulates Human Behavior:** It dictates acceptable and unacceptable conduct in society.

5. **Sanction-Backed**: Any violation of the law attracts legal consequences or punishments (fines, imprisonment, etc.).

IMPORTANCE OF LAW

1. **Maintains Order:** Prevents chaos and anarchy in society.

2. **Promotes Justice:** Ensures fairness, equity, and the protection of the weak.

3. **Regulates Human Conduct:** Sets clear boundaries for what is acceptable behavior.

4. **Facilitates Peaceful Coexistence:** Provides mechanisms for resolving disputes amicably.

THE CONSTITUTION

The Constitution is the supreme law of the land. Its primary functions include: Defining and allocating the powers of the different branches of government (Executive, Legislature, and Judiciary) and housing and safeguarding the fundamental human rights of the citizens.

LEGAL EDUCATION

Legal education refers to the formal training of individuals in the principles, practices, and philosophy of law.

IMPORTANCE OF LEGAL EDUCATION

1. **Trains Legal Practitioners:** It equips future lawyers, judges, and legal scholars with the necessary skills to practice.

2. **Protects Human Rights:** It creates awareness of constitutional rights and trains advocates to defend them.

3. **Promotes the Rule of Law:** It fosters a society that understands, respects, and upholds legal systems.

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TIME MANAGEMENT IN A LEGAL CONTEXT

You cannot actually manage time itself; you can only manage your activities within the time available. Therefore, “time management” is effectively the strategic utilization of time through activity management.

In the legal profession, this is defined as the ability to rank activities by priority to maximize productivity and efficiency.

LEGAL DUTIES AND CASE MANAGEMENT

In this context, legal duties encompass the entire life cycle of handling a legal matter. This includes:

1. Conducting comprehensive case research and analysis.

2. Drafting pleadings, motions, and legal briefs.

3. Interviewing clients and witnesses.

4. Developing legal strategies and representing clients in court.

IMPORTANCE OF TIME /ACTIVITY MANAGEMENT IN LEGAL DUTIES

1. **Meeting Court Deadlines:** Law is governed by rigid statutes of limitations and court-ordered deadlines. Missing a filing can jeopardize a client's case and lead to malpractice claims.

2. **Reducing Stress and Minimizing Errors:** Legal work requires meticulous attention to detail. Proper planning prevents the rush of last-minute filings, which inherently breeds mistakes.

3. **Enhancing Professionalism:** A lawyer who manages their schedule well commands respect from judges, colleagues, and clients, thereby building a stellar professional reputation.

PRACTICAL TIME MANAGEMENT TECHNIQUES

1. **Prioritizing Tasks:** Categorizing assignments based on urgency and importance

2. **Utilizing Digital Calendars and Scheduling Tools:** Setting automated alarms and reminders for court dates, filing deadlines, and client meetings.

3. **Establishing Hard Internal Deadlines:** Setting self-imposed deadlines well ahead of official legal cutoffs to allow ample time for review.

4. **Combating Procrastination:** Breaking complex cases down into smaller, actionable steps to maintain consistent momentum.

ADMINISTRATIVE DISCIPLINE

Administrative discipline is the strict adherence to the established rules, regulations, policies, and protocols of an organization or legal institution.

IMPORTANCE OF ADMINISTRATIVE DISCIPLINE

1. **Promotes Order and Efficiency:** Ensures that the day-to-day operations of a law firm or legal department run smoothly without chaotic bottlenecks.

2. **Encourages Accountability:** Establishes clear boundaries of responsibility, ensuring everyone is answerable for their specific duties.

3. **Prevents Conflict and Confusion:** When clear procedures are followed, it eliminates ambiguity regarding roles, expectations, and case ownership.

4. **Upholds Professionalism:** Alignment with institutional rules reinforces ethical behavior and maintains the integrity of the legal practice.

CORE QUALITIES OF ADMINISTRATIVE DISCIPLINE

1. **Punctuality:** Arriving on time for court sessions, depositions, client consultations, and internal meetings.

2. **Respect:** Demonstrating professional courtesy toward the judiciary, opposing counsel, clients, and administrative staff.

3. **Compliance with Procedures:** Rigorously following internal firm workflows, document retention policies, and formal court rules.

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TYPES OF PRECEDENT

Legal precedents are categorized based on their level of authority over a presiding court.

1. **Binding Precedent:** A rule of law established by a higher court that lower courts within the same judicial hierarchy must follow. For a precedent to be binding, the material facts of the current case must be sufficiently similar to those of the previous case.

2. **Persuasive Precedent:** A legal decision that a court may consider and choose to follow, but is under no legal obligation to do so. Persuasive precedents typically originate from:

- Lower courts within the same hierarchy.
- Courts in foreign jurisdictions (e.g., UK, Commonwealth, or other common law countries).
- Obiter dicta from superior courts.

HIERARCHY OF COURTS

To understand how precedent applies, one must understand the structure of the judiciary. In a standard common law system (such as Nigeria), the hierarchy generally flows from the highest authority downward:

Supreme Court ~ Court of Appeal ~ High Court ~ Magistrate Courts

PARTS OF A JUDGEMENT

A court judgment contains two major components that are critical to the doctrine of precedent:

1. **Ratio Decidendi:** "The reason for the decision." It refers to the principle of law that directly determines the outcome of a case. This is the binding part of the judgement and forms the binding precedent.

2. **Obiter Dicta:** "Statements made in passing." These are remarks, illustrations, opinions, and statements made by the judge that are not essential to resolving the specific legal issue before the court. Obiter dicta do not possess binding authority; however, they carry significant weight and serve as persuasive precedent.

PROCESS OF APPLYING

The process of applying legal precedence involves:

1. The court examines the facts and legal questions of the case.

2(a). If the material facts are substantially similar to a case previously decided by a higher court in the hierarchy, the precedent is binding, and the judge must apply that established rule of law.

2(b). If the case presents an entirely new issue with no existing legal precedent, it is a "fresh case." The presiding judge must deliver a judgment using wisdom, fairness, and bearing the concept of justice in mind.

CIRCUMSTANCES WHEN PRECEDENT MAY NOT BE FOLLOWED

1. **Distinguishing:** A court may decline to follow a precedent if it can demonstrate that the material facts of the current case are fundamentally different from the facts of the past case.

2. **Overruling:** A higher court may explicitly declare a previous decision made by a court of lower status to be incorrect, replacing it with a new rule of law.

3. **Reversing:** This occurs within the same lawsuit when a higher court alters the specific decision of a lower court on appeal.

4. **Decision Per Incuriam**: A judgment delivered “through inadvertence” or ignorance of a relevant constitutional provision, statute, or binding precedent. A decision made per incuriam lacks precendential authority and is not binding.

LIMITATIONS OF LEGAL PRECEDENT

1. **Rigidity in the Law:** It can bind courts to outdated or archaic legal rules that no longer align with modern societal values.

2. **Perpetuation of Errors:** A flawed or poor decision made by a superior court can persist and affect numerous subsequent cases before it is finally corrected or overruled.

3. **Complexity and Confusion:** Navigating a vast library of case law and complex court hierarchies can lead to conflicting interpretations and legal uncertainty.

4. **Delayed Legal Reform:** Relying heavily on past decisions can slow down necessary legal evolution, forcing society to wait for legislative intervention to fix judicial flaws.